



lagers into vans and driving them to the hospital.

By its second year, the Emergency had generated a great deal of fear and terror. Then, in January 1977, and without consulting Sanjay, the Prime Minister announced that she was returning India to democratic rule. In the elections held in March, her Congress party was trounced by a merger, hastily cobbled together, of four older parties that called itself the 'Janata Party'. In the state worst hit by the Emergency, Uttar Pradesh, the rout of the Congress was complete, with both Indira and Sanjay failing to win elections.

Most Indians who lived through the period of their rule dismiss the Janata Party as a bunch of jokers. While broadly true, this characterisation omits to acknowledge one great service that this first non-Congress Government rendered to the nation. During Emergency, a series of Constitutional amendments had been introduced, centralising power in the office and person of the Prime Minister. Now the original provisions were restored.

Directing the restoration were the new Prime Minister Morarji Desai and his hardworking Law Minister Shanti Bhushan. As historian Granville Austin has written, the Janata Government enjoyed a "remarkable success in repairing the Constitution from the Emergency's depredations, in reviving open parliamentary practice through its consultative style...., and in restoring the judiciary's independence".

When Mrs Gandhi lost the elections in 1977, an English friend wrote asking whether she would now 'spend some time enjoying birds, up in the Himalaya, or in Kashmir'. Then

he added: 'We shall try to keep up with the news from India, and perhaps in five years from now, you will be in office once again with the biggest majority ever. Such is democracy!'.

In fact, it took less than three years for Mrs Gandhi to become Prime Minister once more. Towards the end of 1979 the Janata Party collapsed under the weight of its contradictions. In the mid-term poll that resulted, the Congress returned to power. Thus ended a decade momentous in the history of the nation, and momentous also in the life of one particular individual. For between 1970 and 1980, Mrs Gandhi had tasted

Kipling's two impostors, success and failure, in full and equal measure.

The 1970s saw the ascendance of a populist style in Indian politics, with disputes increasingly sought to be resolved in the streets rather than in the legislature. The decade also saw the introduction of the dynastic principle. While Jawaharlal Nehru never wished or hoped that his daughter would become Prime Minister, Mrs Gandhi made it clear that Sanjay would, when the time came,

succeed her. After he died, the succession was transferred by her to Rajiv. In time, the precedent set by India's oldest party was adopted by most others. Now, with the exception of the cadre-based parties of Left and Right, the CPI(M) and the BJP, all political parties have transformed into family firms. That is the legacy of the decade of the 1970s, and of its pre-eminent political figure, Indira Gandhi.

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